



Playfulness Acceptance Curiosity Empathy

With Connection's guide to strengthening relationships between parents and children using **the PACE model**





Playfulness

What is Playfulness?

Playfulness is about creating moments of joy, laughter, and connection.

Why is Playfulness Important?

For a child with a hypersensitive nervous system playfulness can be a key to building **trust** and **connection**.

Your child may not trust adults will be safe, because their nervous system is easily activated and pushed into survival mode.

Playfulness is an effective way to relax your child's nervous system and to remind them that they are safe.



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The Benefits of Playfulness: *for Your Child (and You!)*

Playful interactions help calm the brain's stress responses, making both you and your child more open to **connection**.

Play triggers the release of feel-good hormones like **oxytocin** and **dopamine**, which foster trust and bonding.



Playfulness can help you feel **connected**, **grounded**, and **emotionally balanced**, no matter the challenges.



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Examples of Playfulness

Silly Voices & Sounds

"Can you help me with the dishes? The plates are starting to feel very sleepy. They're saying: 'Please clean us so we can go to sleep in the cupboard!'"

Imaginative Play

"Can you help me with the dishes? The plates are starting to feel very sleepy. They're saying: 'Please clean us so we can go to sleep in the cupboard!'"

Make Necessary Activities Fun

"How fast do you think we can get all the toys in the basket? Let's race against the clock!"

Small, Playful Moments in the Day

"Let's have a silly dance party for two minutes while we wait for dinner to cook! Ready, set, go!"

Making interactions fun, light, and connected allows small moments of joy to spring up, even when bigger moments are hard. This shows your child they are loved, valued and supported, no matter what.



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Acceptance

What is Acceptance?

Acceptance is about seeing beyond behavior and recognizing the **thoughts**, **feelings**, and **experiences** behind it.

All behavior is communication

Acceptance is **NOT** about letting **hurtful** or **harmful** behavior slide, or avoiding setting boundaries or limits.

When we offer acceptance we tell them:

***“I see
your
pain...”***

***... and I
understand
this is hard
for you.”***



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Why Can Acceptance Be Difficult?

You focus on correct behavior immediately

This can trigger shame and defensive reactions in children with hypersensitive nervous systems, making things worse instead of better.

You focus on consequences

Jumping into consequences right away can leave your child missing out on the true learning: recognizing and appropriately responding to their feelings.

You (*understandably!*) want change quickly

Typical discipline works for other kids, why not yours?
Children with sensitive nervous systems need extra time to recognize and appropriately express their feelings.



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Examples of Acceptance

Thanks for letting me know.

That makes sense.

Thanks for sharing something so hard with me.

Thanks for saying that out loud.

Thanks for being so honest, that is so brave.

Thanks for telling me what was happening for you at the time.

I didn't know you felt that way before.

I get it/I understand what you are saying.

I can hear you saying that you hate me and you're really mad.

I can hear you saying you don't trust me right now, that must feel really hard.

I am disappointed, but that doesn't change how much I love you.

Wow! You have a lot of feelings about that.

It seems like you are feeling like you're not being heard.

I see you're upset you cannot... It's tough when the answer is no.



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Curiosity

What is Curiosity?

Curiosity is about asking, “What’s happening for you right now?” and listening with an open heart.

For a child with a sensitive nervous system, **curiosity** allows you to explore what’s going on ***underneath a behavior.***

Ask Open Questions

“You seem upset—can you help me understand what you’re feeling?”

Listen Without Judgement

“I wonder if something happened that made you feel sad today.”

Look Beyond Behavior

“I noticed you avoiding homework—what’s going on?”

When you approach your child with curiosity, it helps them feel safe and understood, especially if they’ve experienced trauma or have a sensitive nervous system. It builds trust and encourages open communication, making it easier for your child to share what’s really going on inside.



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Examples of Curiosity

I wonder if...

My guess is...

Tell me if I am getting this wrong...

Is it possible that...

I want to figure this out...

My sense is...

It sounds like...

What is it like...?

It seems to me... do I have that right?

I think you're saying...

Would it be okay if I take a guess about what you want to say?

My guess is if___ could find the words he would say...

I'm curious if...

I interested to know if...



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Empathy

Why is empathy important?

For a child with a ***highly sensitive nervous system***, empathy is essential to help them feel **seen, heard, and understood**. To practice empathy:

acknowledge
feelings

reflect
emotions

value all
feelings

Empathy allows you to connect with your child in a way that says:

"I understand what
you are going
through, and I am
here for you."



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Examples of Empathy

That must be hard.

I would be sad/mad/frustrated too if that happened to me.

It must be tough for you to talk about this with me.

I can see how you could feel that way.

I am sorry it has been so hard for you.

You seem a little ____ now.

You look really... sad, mad, disappointed, etc.

You seem really... sad, mad, disappointed, etc.

It's scary sometimes when you have to...

No wonder you were so upset...

It hurt your feelings when he... I bet you thought, why would he do that?

You were excited to have another turn, it feels so unfair we ran out of time.

It feels to you like he doesn't like you, I can see how hard that is.

When I said 'no,' it made you angry. I understand why you want space.



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Blocked Care

What is Blocked Care?

Blocked care occurs when, after long periods of stress, your brain and body go into “protection mode.” Instead of feeling warmth and joy toward your child, you may feel numb, distant, resentful, or exhausted

Blocked Care is not a sign you don't love your child. It is your nervous system trying to survive.

Normalize

Blocked care is a state, not who you are. Name it to reduce shame: “I am in blocked care” instead of “I’m a bad parent.”

Care for your Nervous System

Breathe, stretch, exercise, eat, rest, talk to a friend or therapist who understands.

Find Small Connections

Tiny moments, 5 minutes, of warmth: eye contact, a shared laugh, sitting near each other.

Reframe Your Child's Behavior: Behaviors often come from survival strategies, not rejection of you.

Remind yourself: “My child's nervous system is protecting them, just like mine is protecting me.” This can change.



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therapeutic support for children and families

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We work with families who are raising children with big behaviors that feel challenging, confusing and different than their siblings or peers. Often children are neurodivergent, or have experienced trauma, such as foster care, adoption, medical procedures, or family changes. We work collaboratively with families to understand the needs that lie beneath children's behavior and help the whole family heal.

Katie Statman-Weil, EdD, LCSW
&
Helene Hanson, CSWA

We work with parents and their kids with *highly sensitive nervous systems*. We specialize in children who are *neurodiverse* (PDA, ADHD, etc.), children who have experienced *trauma* and/or children who have been touched by *foster care* or *adoption*.

We work alongside your family to ease the chaos and bring joy back into your home.



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